OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

# Mayor Patricia White's local travel claims: $378,738 since 2012/13

Sent 2 November 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 30 November 2026

**Steve Prothero**
**Eye on Shoalhaven Council**

**16 November 2026**
**Mayor Patricia White**
**Shoalhaven City Council**
**By email**

**Dear Mayor White**
**Request for your response before publication: local travel claims, the COVID years and the 10 June 2025 expenses policy items**

**I am preparing an article for Eye on Shoalhaven Council on the cost of councillor expenses.**

**It names you and draws on Council's published expense reports, the minutes of the ordinary meetings of 27 May and 10 June 2025, and public data.**

**I am writing so that you can respond before it is published.**

**The article will state the following, which I have taken from those documents:**
**· Over 2012/13 to 2025/26 your recorded expense claims total $562,980, of which local travelling expenses are $378,738 (67%), an average of $27,053 a year. Your phone claims over the same years total $15,615.**
**· In 12 of those 14 years your local travel claim was the highest of any councillor.**
**· Your local travel claims were $30,772 (2019/20), $35,370 (2020/21) and $24,878 (2021/22). In 2020/21 the next-highest councillor claimed $20,237.**
**· Your local travel claims were $20,044 (2024/25) and $19,357 (2025/26). In 2025/26 this was 57% of all councillor local travel claims ($33,897).**
**· On 10 June 2025 you chaired the ordinary meeting. Council resolved 8 to 5 to rescind the decision of 27 May 2025 (MIN25.256), and 8 to 5 to adopt the Councillor Expenses and Facilities Policy as exhibited, not accept the petition included in report CL25.164 and have the CEO investigate its inclusion (MIN25.278 and MIN25.279). You voted for each motion. Points of order raised on the item were ruled against.**

**Please answer the following questions in writing.**

**Local travel**

1. What mileage rate applied to your claims in each year from 2012/13 to 2025/26, and how many kilometres does each year's local travel total represent?
2. What categories of trip make up your local travel claims (for example Council meetings, briefings, community events, meetings with residents, travel from home to Council chambers)?
3. Do you keep a logbook of date, distance and purpose for each claim? Will you release it?
4. Does the Councillor Expenses and Facilities Policy permit travel from your home to Council chambers or offices to be claimed as official business? If so, under which clause?
5. How many of your local trips could have been conducted by telephone or video, and what steps have you taken to substitute them?
6. Why did your local travel claims fall by 47% between 2018/19 and 2025/26 while those of the other councillors combined fell by 90%?

COVID period

7. What were your $35,370 in local travel claims for 2020/21 for, and how were Council meetings and briefings held that year?

Vehicle options

8. As Mayor, have you considered a Council-provided vehicle as an alternative to claiming mileage? Who made the comparison, what did it show, and who decided?
9. If a Council vehicle were provided, would you support logging private use and deducting it from the mayoral allowance, as section 252(2) of the Local Government Act permits?

The 10 June 2025 items

10. Why did you chair the items on the expenses policy and the petition rather than ask the Deputy Mayor to take the chair for those items?
11. Did you consider whether you had any interest to declare in either item? If you did, what was your conclusion and why?
12. What did the CEO's investigation into the inclusion of the petition cost in staff time, and what did it conclude?

Oversight and publication

13. Who approves and audits councillor travel claims, and has any review compared your claims with the policy?
14. Will you publish a trip-level breakdown of your local travel claims?

I intend to publish after 5pm on Monday 30 November 2026. If you consider any statement above to be inaccurate, please identify it and the document that shows otherwise.

**Yours sincerely**

**Steve Prothero**
**Eye on Shoalhaven Council**

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